didn’t know too much about in advance was that I was going to meet an angel in the tunnel at Old Trafford that afternoon.

The first time I heard about Kirsty Howard was from my Dad in midweek. He phoned to tell me about her:

‘She’s a lovely girl, David, but she’s not well at all. She’s going to come out for kick-off with you on Saturday. Make sure you take good care of her.’

Dad had been involved in the arrangements along with the FA and that’s why he knew all about Kirsty and the Francis House Children’s Hospice she’s raised so much money for. That phone conversation was as much as I was told. When we arrived at Old Trafford on the Saturday afternoon, before I went into the dressing room to get changed, I went down to the tunnel to meet her. Kirsty was waiting for me with her mum and dad and a couple of people from the charity. She was standing patiently, a little girl with a smile almost as big as she was. I saw that smile before I even noticed the oxygen cylinder Kirsty has to wheel around behind her. I sat down on the step next to her and we talked for a few minutes; about what she had to struggle with, her being born with her heart the wrong way round and some of her other organs out of place. She explained how she was trying to raise money for other children at the hospice where she got her treatment. I asked her how she was feeling and, before she could answer, someone behind us said:

‘Do you want to give him a kiss?’

For the first time, Kirsty seemed a little bit embarrassed but she gave me a peck on the cheek anyway and we had a bit of a cuddle. It was time for me to go. I stood up and said:

‘I’ll see you in a minute, though, won’t I? When we go out on the field?’

Kirsty looked back up at me. She nodded and smiled and I went back in to the dressing room. I was miles away. It took me a minute or two to realize that the atmosphere was weird, quiet. Not like this England team. Nobody seemed to have much to say to each other. Sven said:

‘Make sure we get the ball moving quickly.’

Which was exactly what we didn’t do for the rest of that afternoon, of course. The bell rang and it was time to go out. In the tunnel, I came up alongside Kirsty and took her hand. She’s got the tiniest little hands you could imagine, just big enough for her to wrap one around one of my fingers. She